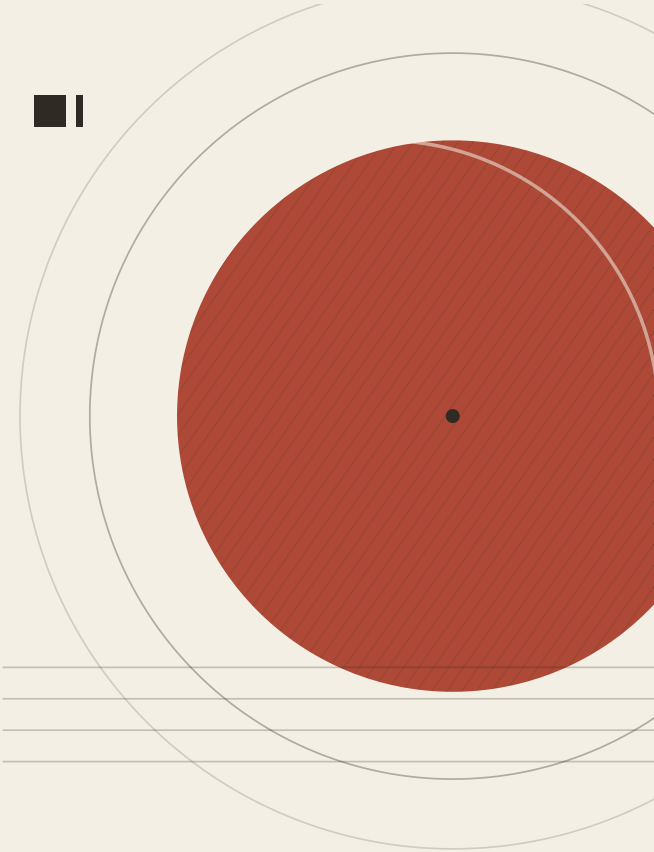
A WEEKLY ANTHOLOGY OF LONGFORM JOURNALISM

Weekend Reads



COVER STORY · SOCIETY & CULTURE

What I Learned About Christmas—And Life—By Starring* in a Hallmark Movie

On a Hallmark movie set, it is always Christmas but rarely winter.

BY ALEXANDRA PETRI · THE ATLANTIC

ISSUE 01
TUESDAY, 10 NOVEMBER 2026
AUTUMN 2026

POLITICS
Can Democrats Hold Trump Accountable?

SCIENCE
The Case for a Bubble at Life's Start

INDIA
The khaki isn't clean: Can India Break Its Colonial Legacy?

TECHNOLOGY
Louis Rossmann Wants More People to Care About the Right to Repair

ISSUE 01 · TUESDAY, 10 NOVEMBER 2026

Contents

10 STORIES · 166 MINUTES OF READING

Issue 01 arrives on Tuesday, 10 November 2026. The cover story is “What I Learned About Christmas—And Life—By Starring* in a Hallmark Movie,” from The Atlantic.

It sits alongside 9 pieces moving through Politics, India, Science, Technology, Global, Ideas, Business, Climate and Longform. Each was chosen for reporting that rewards a slower read. There is no single thread running through the issue, except perhaps attention itself: the willingness to stay with a subject long enough to see its edges.

Every digest links back to the original publication. If a story stays with you, read it there.

01	Culture	What I Learned About Christmas—And Life—By Starring* in a Hallmark Movie	The Atlantic	3
02	Politics	Can Democrats Hold Trump Accountable?	The Atlantic	5
03	India	The khaki isn’t clean: Can India Break Its Colonial Legacy?	Frontline	7
04	Science	The Case for a Bubble at Life’s Start	Quanta Magazine	9
05	Technology	Louis Rossmann Wants More People to Care About the Right to Repair	Wired	11
06	Global	Trump Is Facing a Very Different North Korea	Foreign Affairs	13
07	Ideas	How does Roshi Joan Halifax make sense of her Buddhist life?	Aeon	15
08	Business	Paraguay’s bank collapse brought down a president – and exposed as myth the nation’s status as a ‘Dubai of South America’	The Conversation	17
09	Climate	Analysis: Fossil-fuel CO2 emissions set to dip in 2026 as Iran conflict hits oil use	Carbon Brief	19
10	Longform	The Garbage Man: Bill Gates Has Earned Billions Investing in Climate-Polluting Landfills	ProPublica	21

EVERY DIGEST IS AN EDITORIAL SUMMARY. FOLLOW THE PRINTED SOURCE LINK TO READ THE ORIGINAL.

01

SOCIETY & CULTURE · 31 MIN READ

What I Learned About Christmas—And Life—By Starring* in a Hallmark Movie

On a Hallmark movie set, it is always Christmas but rarely winter.

BY ALEXANDRA PETRI · THE ATLANTIC · 10 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

There were a few evolutionary hops between vassals wassailing and American families zoning out in front of their TV sets, and many of them happened in the 19th century: Charles Dickens's ghost story staved Christmas into a beloved fable of generosity, and The Nutcracker turned the holiday into a hallucinatory nightmare. They are "smart" and "relatable" and have "1,000-watt smiles" but are "no shrinking poinsettias," according to the book Hallmark Channel Countdown to Christmas: Celebrate the Movie Magic (Revised Edition), whose cover promises "Recipes, Watch Party Games & More."

"They are predictably upbeat, generally enjoyable, and feature a suite of actors who become familiar faces over time."

THE STORY

What's more, she loves this town, and her job at the family lumber mill, more than anything—a fact that is lost on her absentee city-slicker boyfriend, Paul, an international wine broker in a tiny sports car. The flurry is now a blizzard, blanketing our screens with mass-produced mirth and brand partnerships—with the NFL (Holiday Touchdown: A Bears Love Story) and Disney World (what if we locked eyes in the hall of animatronic presidents?). Concertgoers should bring burgundies, creams and whites, forest greens, deep reds, beiges, or other "rich winter tones," and are to "dress smart, elegant, and subtly festive." Although she still mentors aspiring Hallmark screenwriters, Joany's main focus these days is Wicked Merry, an original pirate-romance universe inspired, in part, by her love of Jimmy Buffett.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

Have you ever wanted to see Gary Coleman, William Shatner, and (an uncredited) James Cromwell play the ghosts of Christmases past, present, and future? But the key ingredient will always be Christmas, which is an "emotional intensifier" in both Hallmark movies and real life, according to the historian Gerry Bowler, who once wrote a biography of Santa Claus. Mary has detailed, smart advice about using my sense memories of moving through city streets in winter, thinking about how I would hold my arms close to my sides and keep my head down to avoid the wind. Although the chain has a large, sparkling red jewel that vaguely resembles the Eye of Sauron, the accessory is, on closer inspection, held together by a safety pin. Someone down the choir stall—another professional actor, Emily Swain, playing the school headmistress—indicates that she's going to look at me in a significant way when the song medley starts, because it includes the mayor's favorite song.

WHY IT MATTERS

I don't have access to the script, so I can only guess the plot from the snippets of dialogue I hear and the broad outline from Publicist Maria: Jessy Schram is Rose, a choir director from Vienna,

Ohio. “I probably sound obsessed,” she says apologetically, after telling me that she has attended six straight Christmas Cons, has been on two Hallmark cruises, and has a tattoo of the Hallmark crown logo on her arm. It is amazing how you can do any action hundreds or thousands of times without thinking about it, and the second you have to do it for an audience, you become a hapless lump attempting to walk on dry land for the first time. I also email the actual Lord Mayor of Canterbury, a man named Alister Brady whose photo and contact information I find online: “Do you have any advice for someone who wants to wordlessly convey the essence of Mayor of Canterbury?”

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. Concertgoers should bring burgundies, creams and whites, forest greens, deep reds, beiges, or other “rich winter tones,” and are to “dress smart, elegant, and subtly festive.”
2. Although the chain has a large, sparkling red jewel that vaguely resembles the Eye of Sauron, the accessory is, on closer inspection, held together by a safety pin.
3. Have you ever wanted to see Gary Coleman, William Shatner, and (an uncredited) James Cromwell play the ghosts of Christmases past, present, and future?

Original source: **The Atlantic** — https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/12/hallmark-christmas-movie-actor/689028/?utm_source=feed

02

POLITICS · 11 MIN READ

Can Democrats Hold Trump Accountable?

Eight years ago, Democrats harnessed popular anger at Donald Trump to take control of the House. Promising to curb the administration's excesses, they issued a pile of subpoenas and held Cabinet members in contempt.

BY ISAAC STANLEY-BECKER · THE ATLANTIC · 10 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

Over the past two years, Republicans have largely ceded their legislative authority to Trump while adopting a see-no-evil approach to allegations of grift and bribery: the first family accumulating billions in crypto wealth, the president pardoning politically connected convicts, the government awarding contracts to firms funding his pet projects. For almost two years, the business of white-collar law has been down because the Trump administration has used a light touch on corporate and securities fraud, pardoned dozens of high-profile white-collar criminals, and overseen cutbacks of staff once devoted to consumer protection and other kinds of regulatory enforcement.

"Data centers in space looking pretty appealing right now."

THE STORY

Corruption and the cost of living topped the list of concerns for those who gave Democrats their largest popular-vote margin in the House since 1976, when price increases and government malfeasance, exemplified by the Watergate scandal, also infuriated voters. The Justice Department routinely represents executive-branch officials, but regulations bar its lawyers from defending officials whose conduct falls outside the scope of their employment, or when representation would not be in the interest of the United States. Garcia has pledged to conduct oversight in four broad areas: the "Trump Crime Family," as he calls it; abuses at ICE and the Department of Homeland Security; corporate corruption; and what he considers to be the cover-up of the Epstein files by the Trump administration. Representative Jamie Raskin, the incoming chair of the House Judiciary Committee, told me the causes of the most punishing price increases over the past two years—Trump's war in Iran and his tariff war against much of the world—also involve unconstitutional usurpation of congressional authority.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

The biggest obstacle is the term-limited, lame-duck president to whom the Supreme Court has granted executive authority and criminal immunity that dissenting justices found more suited to a king. His rhetoric about corporate malfeasance has been milder than that of some colleagues, but he did introduce a bill, in March, to break up meatpacking monopolies as a way to lower the cost of food. He drew a comparison to the Boston Tea Party: Did the Sons of Liberty hurl the wooden chests into the harbor because of the price of tea, or because of an unjust taxing authority and a state-backed monopoly? Blumenthal said he's especially focused on accountability for the crypto industry, because of the wealth the Trump family has derived from it and the aggressive ways that industry players have sought to buy influence in Washington. (Trump's allies Steve Bannon and Peter Navarro served time in prison for ignoring subpoenas related to the

congressional investigation into January 6, but they were prosecuted during the Biden administration.)

WHY IT MATTERS

I asked Garcia whether he could envision people landing in jail as part of the oversight process, and he demurred, saying the issue would need to be hashed out at the Justice Department or litigated in the courts. Legislation to tighten campaign-finance rules or restore the independence of the Justice Department would face more resistance, David Rapallo, a Georgetown Law professor and former House Oversight staff director, predicts. There are almost too many reasons why—the billions his companies receive in federal contracts, the sweeping cuts he oversaw to the federal government through DOGE, the purported use of his AI chatbot Grok in the planning to capture Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro. And then there's the more than $445 million he spent trying to elect Republicans in federal races this cycle, according to the research nonprofit OpenSecrets, about $226 million of which went to committees focused on Texas, where core elements of Musk's business empire are based.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. He did seem to acknowledge the difficulty he could encounter here on Earth when he wrote on X, "Data centers in space looking pretty appealing right now."
2. Pursuing the Trump family for self-dealing, they intend to argue, serves a higher aim—rectifying a political system rigged toward the rich.
3. A congressional power called inherent contempt, which involves directing the sergeant-at-arms to arrest an obstinate witness, hasn't been used for almost a century.

Original source: **The Atlantic** — https://www.theatlantic.com/politics/2026/11/democrats-trump-investigations-corruption/689354/?utm_source=feed

03

INDIA FOCUS · 11 MIN READ

The khaki isn't clean: Can India Break Its Colonial Legacy?

Indian democracy is often celebrated as the world's largest and one of its most robust.

BY NAVEED MEHMOOD AHMAD · FRONTLINE · 11 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

Consider this: 68 per cent of the police personnel surveyed justified the use of torture against people accused of national security crimes, while 55 per cent supported torture for offences like theft, and 22 per cent advocated killing people considered dangerous in police encounters rather than giving them an opportunity to stand trial (SPIR 2025). For instance, one in three government employees surveyed in SPIR 2023 believed that the government can access people's phones without their knowledge or consent; while 52 per cent of ordinary citizens believed that public CCTV cameras carried a high risk of illegal mass surveillance.

"This omission becomes particularly glaring at a time when agitational politics is once again bringing large numbers of people onto the streets to demand redressal of their grievances."

THE STORY

Armed, organised along semi-military lines, and placed under the direct control of the colonial government, the Irish model was intended to suppress agrarian unrest and check resistance to British rule. For the British, adopting this model in India provided a much more economical alternative to using troops for routine policing, while allowing troops to be concentrated in garrison towns, under close supervision and discipline. As the republic emerged as a constitutional democracy after a long struggle against colonial rule, policing should have been reimagined as public service rather than an instrument of control, meant to assist citizens, uphold constitutional protections and prevent their violation by state and private actors, investigate and prevent crime, and maintain public order. Around the same time, the deaths of an IPS officer and an assistant sub-inspector in Haryana brought into focus allegations of corruption, caste discrimination, favouritism in postings, and misuse of authority within the police hierarchy.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

The guarantees of freedom of speech and assembly, protection against self-incrimination, and safeguards against arbitrary arrest were intended to protect individual liberty in a citizen's interaction with law enforcement. | Photo Credit: PTI This may appear to be a philosophical argument, but a fundamental shift in institutional mindset was necessary to change the way the police functioned, engaged with people, and were perceived by the public. Similarly, a study of wildlife policing in Madhya Pradesh found that 78 per cent of those accused in cases recorded by the forest department belonged to oppressed caste communities (CJAP, 2022). The Commission of Inquiry investigating the Bhagalpur riots of 1989 documented the local police's failure to prevent violence as well as instances of their active participation in facilitating it. The Sachar Committee formed in 2005, in its report on the social, economic, and educational status of

Muslims in India submitted in November 2006, highlighted police high-handedness, over-policing in Muslim localities, and arbitrary detentions.

WHY IT MATTERS

The persistence of colonial belief systems, political interference, weak accountability, discriminatory enforcement, and arbitrary exercise of powers continue to raise questions about the nature of policing in India. While retaining the powers essential to effective policing is important, their exercise must not be allowed to circumvent due process, and they must be periodically tested against necessity and proportionality. Recruitment should promote diversity and equal opportunity; personnel must be regularly trained to uphold fundamental freedoms and engage with citizens fairly; while supervision and accountability mechanisms should ensure that abuse of power has consequences. This is perhaps the most important consideration at a time when opposition parties and young people with no political affiliation are confronting the police on the streets, having found themselves voiceless in other democratic forums.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. Much of the debate on what makes a democracy strong is centred on its four institutional pillars: the legislature, the executive, the judiciary, and the media.
2. The rebellion deepened British mistrust in the army, and the military character and growing strength of existing police forces raised concerns.
3. Enforcing these laws required a centrally controlled institution capable of maintaining order, gathering intelligence, and suppressing resistance.

Original source: **Frontline** — https://frontline.thehindu.com/the-nation/human-rights/indian-police-reforms-colonial-legacy-accountability/article71659636.ece

04

SCIENCE & NATURE · 5 MIN READ

The Case for a Bubble at Life's Start

Is self-enclosure life's greatest trick? According to the lipid-first theory of the origin of life, a cell membrane gave primordial chemistry a place to gather.

BY BY PERRI THALER NOVEMBER 10, 2026 · QUANTA MAGAZINE · 10 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

Without a physical boundary corralling molecules into a small space, whatever it was that turned into early life would have been too dispersed to assemble the complex systems that life requires, said Bruce Damer, an astrobiologist at the University of California, Santa Cruz. In 2000, Doron Lancet, a geneticist at the Weizmann Institute of Science, and Daniel Segrè, a computational biologist at Boston University, published the results of a computer model that explored whether these dynamics could lead to lifelike behavior. Researchers have proposed that certain minerals, such as iron sulfides, could have formed the walls of a container, or that coacervates — liquidlike droplets where molecules gather and concentrate — could have acted as membrane-free vessels for early chemistry.

"The idea of a lipid-only form of primitive life has never made sense to me."

THE STORY

In this framework, known as the "lipid first" hypothesis, Earth transitioned from a mess of primordial chemistry to something recognizably alive because of those containers. In the 1990s, researchers imagined a different possibility: What if a chemical system, rather than a molecule, could carry heritable information and become subject to evolution? Each of these may get some A's and some B's, and the symbiotic loop will keep running, building the parent's compositional recipe more faithfully than chance alone would. In our chemical soup, that possibility comes from a stray molecule C, which like a mutation tips a bubble into a different molecular loop.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

Modern life accomplishes this with complex biochemicals such as DNA and RNA, which can encode and copy information in their sequences. They found that bubbles can pass their compositions to their daughters, which vary and compete, fulfilling the requirements for natural selection. The team settled on lipids, the molecules that make up modern cell membranes, in part because they mirror the model's required half-hydrophobic, half-hydrophilic nature. Under the right conditions, the sheets close in on themselves, forming a sphere with a pocket of water trapped inside. But in the 25 years since Lancet, Segrè, and their colleagues published the original lipid-world hypothesis, scientists have questioned whether the first compartments had to be made of lipids at all.

WHY IT MATTERS

They now study whether the repeated drying and refilling of such pools could have squeezed simple molecules between layers of lipids to develop increasingly complex systems. Origins-of-life research is famously contentious, and scientists in the field debate the lipid world against other ideas about how life formed. "The idea of a lipid-only form of primitive life has never made sense to me," said Jack Szostak, a Nobel Prize–winning biochemist at the University of Chicago. A 2010 analysis suggested that the replication of

compositional information from one generation to the next would be too inaccurate for natural selection to work.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. “The idea of a lipid-only form of primitive life has never made sense to me,” said Jack Szostak, a Nobel Prize–winning biochemist at the University of Chicago.
2. They now study whether the repeated drying and refilling of such pools could have squeezed simple molecules between layers of lipids to develop increasingly complex systems.
3. The team settled on lipids, the molecules that make up modern cell membranes, in part because they mirror the model’s required half-hydrophobic, half-hydrophilic nature.

Original source: **Quanta Magazine** — https://www.quantamagazine.org/the-case-for-a-bubble-at-lifes-start-20261110/

05

EMERGING TECHNOLOGY · 27 MIN READ

Louis Rossmann Wants More People to Care About the Right to Repair

The outspoken consumer rights advocate knows the incoming Democrat-heavy Congress has a lot to get done. But he hopes one of those things is letting you fix your own iPhone.

BY BRIAN BARRETT · WIRED · 10 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

Manufacturers have put similar locks on all kinds of gadgets, from video game consoles to cars to smart home devices, making them hard to modify and even harder to restore after some firmware update renders a certain feature unusable. To find out what's next for the right-to-repair movement, I went straight to the source: Louis Rossmann, a YouTuber and consumer rights advocate who recently organized the Own Your Shit tour, which went around the US earlier this year to call for the death of Section 1201 of the Digital Millennium Copyright Act, which prohibits users from bypassing digital restrictions put on devices by manufacturers.

"By the way, you should know that Apple tells the company that makes this chip not to sell it to me, and if everybody in that chain listened, I would not be able to fix this, and you wouldn't have any of your data back."

THE STORY

Apple did start offering self-repair services a few years ago, but it involves renting nearly 80 pounds of equipment and requires you to use official parts. I have over 1,000 repair videos on YouTube where I show people how to do what I do, and there are people that say, "I was working at Walmart for seven bucks an hour, and I picked up a soldering iron and started fixing boards on eBay, and now I make triple what I did before." Is part of the future of owning our things also making it easier to not just tinker with the hardware aspect of it, but to get into the software and make it more in line with what we want out of our experiences and give companies less control over the advertising, the spyware, whatever it is?

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

I see that it's a bent pin in a screen cable because whoever had worked on it before had likely tried to misroute the screen cable when they were plugging it into the board, so they were stretching it, and they shorted pin one to ground, which caused the backlight to go out. We've seen stories in recent weeks where now that people have Claude Code they can use it to check their smart TVs and get rid of all the bloatware and all the adware and have a more streamlined smart TV experience. But what I'm hoping to see happen is that there are enough local models that run on your system that you don't have to worry about some company that gets to tell you what you can do, being able to help people get around all these types of digital locks and bullshit. Section 1201 of the DMCA makes it illegal to bypass a technical protection measure, otherwise known as a digital lock, to gain access to a protected work, even if it's for the purpose of repair. You do have a couple of politicians who actually have been speaking out about the right to repair who are in office now: Josh Turek in Iowa; Jake Johnson in Minnesota looks like he's gonna get a seat.

WHY IT MATTERS

If you wanna replace the entire display assembly, meaning the entire lid on the laptop because that's easier for you, and you're willing to pay an extra $100 or $200 to buy the screen preassembled, go for it. I was able to show my 79-year-old father how to pirate television, movies, music, and it took me less than 10 minutes to show him how to use something like SoulSeek or Usenet to be able to get whatever he wants. If people are concerned about the economy, culture-war issues, if somebody's concerned about immigration or Covid or policing—there're so many issues that resonate far more with the voting public than this. I remember somebody asking me, "Like, no offense Louis, but I'd rather see them spend time on, I don't know, getting rid of Pete Hegseth."

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. Apple did start offering self-repair services a few years ago, but it involves renting nearly 80 pounds of equipment and requires you to use official parts.
2. I remember somebody asking me, "Like, no offense Louis, but I'd rather see them spend time on, I don't know, getting rid of Pete Hegseth."
3. We also discussed the US midterm elections, putting out bounties to find product fixes, and what will happen as the right-to-repair movement collides with the rise of AI.

Original source: **Wired** — https://www.wired.com/story/the-big-interview-podcast-louis-rossmann-right-to-repair/

06

GLOBAL AFFAIRS & GEOPOLITICS · 16 MIN READ

Trump Is Facing a Very Different North Korea

Donald Trump has Pyongyang on his mind. In recent months, the U.S. president has made comments to the media suggesting he is in communication with North Korean leader Kim Jong Un.

BY EMMA CHANLETT-AVERY · FOREIGN AFFAIRS · 11 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

In return, Pyongyang has received generous assistance from Moscow in violation of international sanctions, including abundant financial support for Kim's regime and technology transfers that have enhanced North Korean military capabilities and may help Pyongyang more accurately deliver intercontinental ballistic missiles aimed at the United States. In exchange for stepping away from denuclearization, Trump should demand that Kim freeze any further expansion of his arsenal and explore possibilities for greater strategic stability, including renewed inter-Korean dialogue, transparency and confidence-building efforts, security measures that bolster nuclear facilities' safety and guard against accidents, and strict adherence to nonproliferation.

"The U.S.-Israeli war with Iran has drawn Washington's focus away from Asia as, for the third time in the past quarter century, U.S. strategic attention and military assets have surged to the Middle East."

THE STORY

The fallout from unfinished diplomacy during Trump's first term, the COVID-19 pandemic, and global trends such as the sharp escalation in U.S.-Chinese strategic rivalry and Russia's invasion of Ukraine have destabilized the security landscape and created formidable obstacles to peaceful engagement. Russian aggression has spurred Armenia and Moldova to look westward, and hundreds of thousands of young Russian men have fled the country to avoid military conscription while over a thousand Western companies have left. This approach will require serious diplomacy to minimize second-order consequences, particularly to avoid weakening U.S. alliances in the Indo-Pacific or triggering a collapse of the nuclear nonproliferation regime among nations that might see their only recourse as acquiring their own nuclear weapons. Although lifting international sanctions would require UN Security Council consensus, Trump may be willing to reduce unilateral U.S. sanctions, which he considers an obstacle to better bilateral relations and which have been ineffective in stemming Pyongyang's nuclear advances.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

International sanctions are starving Russia of badly needed capital and technology, and Russian war policies have created huge imbalances and inflation, possibly with worse to come for the Russian economy. While a performative summit alone would be of little benefit to U.S. interests, Washington could use reengagement with Pyongyang to thaw inter-Korean relations and stabilize the peninsula by slowing or freezing North Korea's nuclear buildup. Kim has little reason to meet with Trump now, unless he calculates that he can secure major terms such as de facto recognition as a nuclear state, reduced

sanctions, or a complete withdrawal of U.S. troops from the peninsula. Kim would likely insist that there be no discussion of denuclearization, North Korea's support for the invasion of Ukraine, Pyongyang's human rights abuses, or a final accounting for Japanese citizens kidnapped by North Korea under the rule of Kim Il Sung. Finally, North Korea and the United States—and perhaps, in time, South Korea and Japan—should sustain diplomatic engagement by agreeing to assign diplomats to each other's capitals through reciprocal liaison offices, which would maintain relations without granting full diplomatic recognition.

WHY IT MATTERS

Their absence from the negotiating table may actually accelerate U.S.–North Korean engagement, because coordination across allied governments can be unwieldy and slow, and Pyongyang has not been receptive to past overtures by Seoul and Tokyo. The bruising Republican defeat in the U.S. midterm elections could also change North Korea's diplomatic calculus, especially because it suggests Trump's political standing in the United States has faltered, and he may struggle to deliver the results Kim seeks. If leader-to-leader talks occur, both sides should remember the central lesson from Trump's first-term summits: engagement without sufficient preparation and clearly defined goals is not enough to strengthen security and stability on the Korean Peninsula. Growing tensions in the Indo-Pacific raise the prospect of a much darker future, where conditions on the Korean Peninsula remain unchanged and Asia's entanglements in European and Middle Eastern conflicts metastasize into a new world war—perhaps ignited in Taiwan, the South China Sea, or the Korean Peninsula.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. Asian economies—many of which are deeply dependent on Middle Eastern energy supplies—have contracted as the Strait of Hormuz has remained compromised.
2. One possible formula for progress is focusing, at least temporarily, on steady arms control and international safety controls rather than the elusive goal of denuclearization.
3. Should Seoul move in that direction, Tokyo would almost certainly reconsider its own nonnuclear status, potentially igniting a nuclear arms race in Asia.

Original source: **Foreign Affairs** — https://www.foreignaffairs.com/north-korea/trump-facing-very-different-north-korea

07

PHILOSOPHY & IDEAS · 24 MIN READ

How does Roshi Joan Halifax make sense of her Buddhist life?

Six weeks after two open-heart surgeries in 12 days, Roshi Joan Halifax invited me for a visit. She was recovering, but feeling ‘weak as a kitten’.

BY BEN DAITZ · AEON · 10 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

Robinson and her three daughters lived across the railroad tracks in West Coconut Grove, then known as ‘Coloured Town’, in what Halifax called a ‘concrete monster’ – one of the mould-filled, roach-infested semi-high-rises baking in the Florida heat. Mainstream medicine was often inaccessible or inadequate to Miami’s growing Latin American and Caribbean communities, and many people instead sought care from alternative, often unlicensed practitioners – a clínica, a storefront doctor’s office of uncertain legality, or a santero, a priest of the Afro-Cuban religion of Lukumí, or Santería.

“She was staying with Wendy Lau, her close friend, an emergency physician and Zen priest whose home overlooks Upaya, the Zen centre Halifax established in 1990 in the foothills above Santa Fe in New Mexico.”

THE STORY

Not long after, at the Dade County Jail clinic I’d helped start, a 20-year-old Cuban inmate named Jose – ‘normal’ when arrested for burglary the night before – sat staring and unresponsive in what appeared to be a catatonic trance. Several months after the exorcism, at a meeting of the American Psychiatric Association in Dallas, Halifax met Stanislav Grof, a Czech psychiatrist who had pioneered LSD research and was studying its effects on patients dying of cancer at the Maryland Psychiatric Research Center. Halifax wore a black Icelandic dress and a peaked crown representing a glacier; the world religions scholar Huston Smith officiated, and the mythology scholar Joseph Campbell gave her away. In 1973, amid Halifax’s personal crisis, she and Grof went to Esalen, the experimental community on the cliffs of Big Sur in California, where psychedelics mingled with Zen and other contemplative traditions.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

I want to be like that’ At the H Sophie Newcomb women’s college of Tulane University in New Orleans, the disparity Halifax had registered as a child became something she could act on. The work began with preparation, including meetings with family members; on the day of the LSD session, Halifax might remain with a patient from 7:30 am until midnight, through the experience and the crucial period of integration afterward. Death came to seem to her less like medicine’s failure than ‘the final developmental stage in a person’s life’ – one that called for attention even when curing was no longer possible. Altruism, the impulse that sends a person toward others in need, for instance, can curdle into its own kind of harm – resulting in helping that costs the helper great distress, or strips the one being helped of the power to act for themselves. On one retreat, some 150 people sat in the November rain on the railway tracks at the selection site, eating little more than soup and old bread as the names of people who had died there were read slowly ‘in the four directions’.

WHY IT MATTERS

I always felt like a bull in a china shop' Around 1980, she moved to California to develop the Ojai Foundation, where Buddhist teachers and their communities could gather and practise. His gesture made her see the pity within her grief – and that she had to let him go Meanwhile, Halifax returned to a question she'd been asking since Miami: what could she offer someone when there was nothing left to cure? As Halifax explains in Standing at the Edge, Glassman's form of Buddhism – and hers – meant letting go of fixed ideas, attending to suffering and joy, and allowing that encounter to guide how one helped. Over the decades, the work had grown into a shared undertaking: Nepali doctors, nurses and dentists joined international clinicians, practitioners of Eastern and Western medicine learned from one another, and the clinic opened paths into medicine and nursing for Nepalis.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. The Halifaxes lived in Coral Gables in Florida, a restricted, all-white enclave where neither Jews nor African Americans were allowed to live.
2. In early 1969, Halifax drove a VW bus, modified for desert driving, from Germany to Marseilles in France and on to a ship bound for Oran, on the Algerian coast.
3. When I'd last seen her, three or four years earlier, her hair had been shorn in a Zen tonsure; now it hung in a lush, grey-streaked braid to the middle of her back.

Original source: **Aeon** — https://aeon.co/essays/how-does-roshi-joan-halifax-make-sense-of-her-buddhist-life

08

BUSINESS & ECONOMICS · 7 MIN READ

Paraguay's bank collapse brought down a president – and exposed as myth the nation's status as a 'Dubai of South America'

Protesters on Nov. 5 burn a effigy depicting now ex-President Santiago Pena outside Congress in Asuncion, Paraguay, days after the beginning of a banking crisis to which he was linked.

BY JOEL E. CORREIA, ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR IN HUMAN DIMENSIONS OF NATURAL RESOURCES, COLORADO STATE... · THE CONVERSATION · 09 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

As scholars with expertise in various aspects of Paraguay's contemporary political, economic and environment development, we believe the collapse raises troubling questions about who benefits from financial modernization, who controls it and who bears the risks when it fails. The political relationships through which financial institutions grow, regulators exercise authority and public resources are entrusted to private companies are crucial national concerns, especially in a country that has presented itself internationally as a model of economic stability. Peña previously directed Banco Basa, linked to Colorado Party leader and former President Horacio Cartes, who retains considerable influence and was instrumental in helping push Peña out of office.

"The central bank finally acted after accounting adjustments left Ueno's solvency ratio below half the legal minimum."

THE STORY

In a matter of days, the financial situation escalated into political crisis, in which the country's president was ousted, placed under house arrest and charged with several corruption-related crimes. That included a supervisory report put out by the bank regulators in June 2026 that described roughly US$146 million in loans to three companies linked to Grupo Vázquez, Ueno's controlling shareholder. In any case, Ueno's problems were exposed in dramatic fashion on Nov. 2, when the central bank placed Ueno into resolution, a process similar to bankruptcy but managed directly by Paraguay's central bank. Under Peña-appointed chairman Jorge Brítez, IPS relaxed eligibility requirements for bank deposits in 2023 and removed a capital-based exposure limit in 2024.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

That these warning signs went unheeded raises a related question of why regulators didn't have a better handle on the situation and were not better able to contain the exposure. He was swiftly put under house arrest, charged with corruption and succeeded by his Vice President Pedro Alliana, who was sworn in to serve until 2028. Grupo Vázquez's technology firm ITTI won at least $2.3 million in state contracts after Peña took office, versus $675,000 before. On Oct. 23, the country became the 26th signatory to the Pax Silica Declaration, an initiative involving critical minerals, hydropower and advanced computing infrastructure. While the announcement did not

specify financing commitments, it shows how Paraguay's resources and perceived political predictability are being positioned as strategic assets.

WHY IT MATTERS

Meanwhile, the crisis has led to widespread protests, including outside Congress, with citizens accusing Peña and the ruling Colorado Party of " stealing" their savings. Paraguay's deposit guarantee, which covers balances up to about $38,000, is meant to limit depositor losses, and the Paraguayan Central Bank insists that failure is isolated in the latest case. Yet for most Paraguayans, the crisis was experienced not through technical financial or macroeconomic indicators but at the stark level of seeing from their phones that they couldn't access their money. The test is how Paraguayan legislators and regulators will move forward and whether they separate banking supervision and public deposits from partisan and business networks.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. On Oct. 23, the country became the 26th signatory to the Pax Silica Declaration, an initiative involving critical minerals, hydropower and advanced computing infrastructure.
2. Under Peña-appointed chairman Jorge Brítez, IPS relaxed eligibility requirements for bank deposits in 2023 and removed a capital-based exposure limit in 2024.
3. He was swiftly put under house arrest, charged with corruption and succeeded by his Vice President Pedro Alliana, who was sworn in to serve until 2028.

Original source: **The Conversation** — https://theconversation.com/paraguays-bank-collapse-brought-down-a-president-and-exposed-as-myth-the-nations-status-as-a-dubai-of-south-america-296112

09

CLIMATE & ENVIRONMENT · 15 MIN READ

Analysis: Fossil-fuel CO2 emissions set to dip in 2026 as Iran conflict hits oil use

Carbon dioxide (CO2) emissions from fossil fuels and cement are projected to fall by around 0.4% in 2026 to 38.2bn tonnes of CO2 (GtCO2), according to new figures from the Global Carbon Project.

BY CARBON BRIEF STAFF · CARBON BRIEF · 10 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

Research published alongside the report by the same team in Nature Climate Change finds that the growth in solar, wind and electric vehicles (EVs) now offsets around two-thirds of the emissions that would otherwise come from rising energy demand. This is in line with Carbon Brief analysis showing that China's emissions fell in the second quarter of 2026 as oil use dropped, though it remains too early to determine if this decline reflects a peaking of emissions. The researchers conclude that the 2026 decline is "not a sign that emissions have peaked from the transition to cleaner energy", but more likely a short-term response to higher oil prices.

"Limiting warming to well below 2C – let alone 1.5C, with a remaining budget of just three and a half years of current emissions – requires emissions to fall rapidly towards net-zero, not just stop rising."

THE STORY

While the slowdown reflects real progress, a plateau in emissions is still a long way from the rapid declines needed to reach net-zero emissions and stabilise global temperatures. The report attributes the increase to peat fires, almost all ignited by people, and forest degradation in south-east Asia due to drier conditions associated with El Niño. A study published in parallel by the team behind the global carbon budget reveals that growth in EVs accounted for around a fifth of the overall drop in oil emissions in 2026. This is consistent with Carbon Brief analysis published in September that estimated that global fossil-fuel emissions were set to fall in 2026 amid the Hormuz crisis.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

Estimates of land-use emissions have also been revised, including a spike in 2018 – visible in the chart above – linked to updated cropland data for Colombia. The report attributes this to strong growth in renewables and milder summer temperatures than 2025's record highs, which reduced demand for cooling. The global carbon budget links most of the oil decline to higher prices and reductions in output after the Iran conflict resulted in the closure of the strait of Hormuz. The changes to the land carbon sink in the tropics driven by the El Niño of that year occurred late in the calendar year, so they straddle the 1 January boundary used to calculate annual growth. In the study, the researchers estimate the emissions "avoided" by solar and wind power and EVs, assuming that in their absence the same energy services would have been supplied by fossil fuels.

WHY IT MATTERS

Brazil, the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) and Indonesia together accounted for 2.6GtCO2 of land-use emissions per year over 2015-

25, or around 54% of the global total. A strong El Niño began in June 2026, but its effects on the carbon cycle are not yet visible, as changes in the carbon cycle lag several months behind changes in the climate. Currently, just 10% of the global car fleet has been electrified – a figure that drops to 6% if non-plug-in hybrid cars are excluded. It assumes that each unit of clean energy displaces fossil fuels one-for-one without incorporating potential rebound effects, such as the impact of falling clean energy costs on energy demand and fossil fuel costs.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. The report attributes the increase to peat fires, almost all ignited by people, and forest degradation in south-east Asia due to drier conditions associated with El Niño.
2. A study published in parallel by the team behind the global carbon budget reveals that growth in EVs accounted for around a fifth of the overall drop in oil emissions in 2026.
3. This is consistent with Carbon Brief analysis published in September that estimated that global fossil-fuel emissions were set to fall in 2026 amid the Hormuz crisis.

Original source: **Carbon Brief** — https://www.carbonbrief.org/analysis-fossil-fuel-co2-emissions-set-to-dip-in-2026-as-iran-conflict-hits-oil-use

10

LONGFORM DEEP DIVES · 19 MIN READ

The Garbage Man: Bill Gates Has Earned Billions Investing in Climate-Polluting Landfills

In November 2015, world leaders descended on Paris to negotiate a historic agreement to limit global warming.

BY ALEX CUADROS · PROPUBLICA · 10 NOV 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

Gates, with his characteristic flop of sandy hair, grinned impishly as President Barack Obama called him a “visionary” and a “driving force” behind a pair of pledges that both saw as key to the larger agreement. Mark Felix for ProPublica Most of that trash — 240 million tons a year, enough to bury Manhattan under 100 feet of refuse — is hauled to one of the country’s 1,400 active landfills, where hulking vehicles with spiked wheels crush it into thin layers.

“It’s like you’ve got a mousetrap, and it catches mice.”

THE STORY

“It seems very likely that Bill Gates has the power to influence Republic’s behavior to make it more climate-friendly, even if that costs the company profits,” said Ann Lipton, a legal scholar who studies corporate governance at the University of Colorado, Boulder. To fund his plan to give away virtually his entire fortune, he said he’d given his personal money manager, Michael Larson, a simple remit: Sell Microsoft shares, buy safe, boring assets. Each day, Americans throw away melon rinds, salmon skins and half-eaten drumsticks, paper towels, cheese that was too funky and eggs a day past their sell-by date. The workers also showed off large, bright blue, snail-shaped “blowers” — machines that suck that gas into a network of pipelines, then push it to the clanking, humming on-site plant that turns it into a salable product.

WHAT THE REPORTING SHOWS

The gas can trap 80 times more heat than carbon dioxide in the near term, and it’s responsible for one-third of the global warming we experience today, according to the United Nations Environment Programme. It was only in the ’90s that federal regulators started requiring operators to collect leachate (garbage juice, which can contaminate groundwater) and, at larger facilities, landfill gas (which is typically about half methane and half carbon dioxide but can also contain carcinogens like benzene). According to researchers at Carbon Mapper, a NASA partner that measures emissions from various industries, some operators may prioritize collecting gas with higher methane content, which is cheaper to process — allowing more of the remaining methane to leak out. Environmental Protection Agency Around the time of the Houston Chronicle visit, Republic’s CEO, a former McKinsey consultant named Jon Vander Ark, was promoting a new slogan: “Sustainability in action.” While that is only four board members among a total of 13, Gates’ dominant shareholding means that, “as a practical matter, on any matter that gets voted on, he will almost certainly control the outcome,” said Lipton, the corporate-governance expert.

WHY IT MATTERS

In September 2024, the Environmental Protection Agency issued an “enforcement alert” saying that landfills across the country were “ violating monitoring and maintenance requirements.” It is a tactic from the playbook of another major climate polluter, the oil and gas industry, said Katherine Blauvelt of Full Circle Future, which advocates for cleaning up landfills. “A lot of the issue comes down to the profit of the corporate landfill operators and their resistance to do things that will eat into that,” said Darin Schroeder of the Clean Air Task Force, a climate advocacy group. Larson and Thomas Handley, a Cascade senior adviser, both participate actively in Republic’s board discussions, according to a fellow director who spoke on the condition of anonymity to share details of those private discussions.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1. Each day, Americans throw away melon rinds, salmon skins and half-eaten drumsticks, paper towels, cheese that was too funky and eggs a day past their sell-by date.
2. The top of each well sprouted from the grassy slopes in the form of a stubby black pipe fitted with a valve for adjusting the flow of underground gas.
3. Despite Republic’s economic incentive to capture methane, EPA inspectors found evidence of “poor maintenance” and “careless operation” of the gas-collection system as well.

Original source: **ProPublica** — https://www.propublica.org/article/bill-gates-republic-landfill-methane-pollution

COLOPHON

About this issue

Issue 01 was edited for Tuesday, 10 November 2026 by the Weekend Reads desk. It gathers 10 longform stories from 9 publications. Summaries are editorial digests, not replacements for the originals; all reporting and quotations remain with their publishers.

Editing: Local editorial engine. **Generated:** 12 Nov 2026, 03:02 UTC.

SOURCES IN THIS ISSUE

1. **What I Learned About Christmas—And Life—By Starring* in a Hallmark Movie** — Alexandra Petri, The Atlantic
https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/12/hallmark-christmas-movie-actor/689028/?utm_source=feed

2. **Can Democrats Hold Trump Accountable?** — Isaac Stanley-Becker, The Atlantic
https://www.theatlantic.com/politics/2026/11/democrats-trump-investigations-corruption/689354/?utm_source=feed

3. **The khaki isn't clean: Can India Break Its Colonial Legacy?** — Naveed Mehmood Ahmad, Frontline
https://frontline.thehindu.com/the-nation/human-rights/indian-police-reforms-colonial-legacy-accountability/article71659636.ece

4. **The Case for a Bubble at Life's Start** — By Perri Thaler November 10, 2026, Quanta Magazine
https://www.quantamagazine.org/the-case-for-a-bubble-at-lifes-start-20261110/

5. **Louis Rossmann Wants More People to Care About the Right to Repair** — Brian Barrett, Wired
https://www.wired.com/story/the-big-interview-podcast-louis-rossmann-right-to-repair/

6. **Trump Is Facing a Very Different North Korea** — Emma Chanlett-Avery, Foreign Affairs
https://www.foreignaffairs.com/north-korea/trump-facing-very-different-north-korea

7. **How does Roshi Joan Halifax make sense of her Buddhist life?** — Ben Daitz, Aeon
https://aeon.co/essays/how-does-roshi-joan-halifax-make-sense-of-her-buddhist-life

8. **Paraguay's bank collapse brought down a president – and exposed as myth the nation's status as a 'Dubai of South America'** — Joel E. Correia, Associate Professor in Human Dimensions of Natural Resources, Colorado State..., The Conversation
https://theconversation.com/paraguays-bank-collapse-brought-down-a-president-and-exposed-as-myth-the-nations-status-as-a-dubai-of-south-america-296112

9. **Analysis: Fossil-fuel CO2 emissions set to dip in 2026 as Iran conflict hits oil use** — Carbon Brief Staff, Carbon Brief
https://www.carbonbrief.org/analysis-fossil-fuel-co2-emissions-set-to-dip-in-2026-as-iran-conflict-hits-oil-use

10. **The Garbage Man: Bill Gates Has Earned Billions Investing in Climate-Polluting Landfills** — Alex Cuadros, ProPublica
https://www.propublica.org/article/bill-gates-republic-landfill-methane-pollution

WEEKEND READS · ISSUE 01 · TUESDAY, 10 NOVEMBER 2026 · END.